But did the ancients see the pronouncing of a prophecy in the way that we do? Prophecy, as a narrative technique, was employed by the epic poets in Greece. There, such prophecies, by anticipating what would befall the protagonist, apparently ensured that those following the narration did so with heightened interest. The episodes connected with the return and vengeance of the Greek hero Odysseus in the *Odyssey* are an example of this, for through prophecies readers see in advance 'the doom that awaits the suitors at the hands of Penelope's much tried lord' much before it comes to pass.[21] Sophocles' play *Oedipus Rex* follows fundamentally the same principle: it is the chronicle of a doom not only foretold, but foretold very early on. The point such narratives seem to drive home is that 'plot' is more important than 'story', if by story we mean asking the question 'what happens next?' and if by 'plot' we want to know 'in what way did this happen?' So, it may well be that in some ancient literary cultures, rather than taking away the suspense, prophecy is considered as having aroused and maintained it. Possibly, this in part explains the ancient legend around Ashoka where the prediction by the Buddha gave the story a sense of unity. It ensured that the attention of readers and listeners was never diverted from the unfolding of the main plot even as the trials and tribulations of the hero, and those whose lives he touched, were fleshed out.

Predictions about Ashoka's 'coming' recur on two occasions in the narrative, though the predictors are different. The text has travelled some distance by then, into the arena of action involving the future emperor's real life (in contradistinction to his previous life). Now, the prophecy is first repeated when a beautiful young woman, who in the near future will become his mother, enters the narrative. We will call the woman simply his 'mother' because her true name eludes us. She is known by various names elsewhere, sometimes as Subhadrangi, also as Dharma, at times Durdhara.[22] Buddhist texts do not think it necessary to give her a stable name. Where she comes from, her native place, is not usually mentioned in the ancient